

BEYOND THE CREST

World Building — Document 11

A Daytime Drama

The world of *Beyond the Crest*, from 1939 to the premiere
Monday, January 5, 2026

1. The Rules of This World

***Beyond the Crest* takes place in our world with one great difference: in 1939, a paperboy from Auburn Avenue named Alexander Donohue started a newspaper, and never stopped. Everything that grew from that decision is real in this universe. Everything else is the world as we know it.**

- **Real places and institutions.** Atlanta, Georgia, the United States, Spelman, Morehouse, Grady, Lake Lanier, the Chattahoochee, the NYSE, the Oscars, the Tonys, the FIFA World Cup: all of it exists and works the way it does in real life.
- **Fictional people in power.** Every President, governor, mayor, police chief, judge, CEO, and billionaire seen or named on screen is fictional. Real public figures are never portrayed.
- **Real history, bent by the Donohues.** The big events of American history still happen: the war, the movement, the Olympics, the crash, the pandemic. The Donohues were in the room for many of them.
- **Real calendar.** Holidays, election days, and award shows land on their real 2026 dates.
- **Party names are never spoken.** America still has two major parties, but the show never names them on screen. Jasmine's affiliation stays open.
- **In-universe media only.** Every article, broadcast, and post comes from outlets and platforms that exist inside this world (Section 6).

2. The Donohue Effect: How This World Differs From Ours

In our world	In the world of <i>Beyond the Crest</i>
The most valuable company is worth a few trillion dollars	The Donohue Company is worth \$10 trillion . No other company is worth even half as much
Hollywood is in Los Angeles	Atlanta is the media capital of the world . More film, TV, and music is made in metro Atlanta than in Los Angeles and New York combined
The richest people are tech founders	The richest person on Earth is a 34-year-old Black actor and heir: Marc-Anthony Bullock
Black-owned media is a small share of the industry	The largest media company on the planet has been Black-owned since 1939
Organized crime is fragmented	One syndicate, Blackwater , is larger than any criminal organization in history, and it pays rent for grandmothers
Consumer brands advertise everywhere	Almost no consumer brand can reach a mass audience without buying Donohue airtime. Smilley hates that more than anyone
EGOTs are extremely rare	One Atlanta family holds two of them at the premiere, and four by June 2026

3. The United States, January 2026

The Nation

- America is heading into its **250th birthday** on Saturday, July 4, 2026, the Semiquincentennial. The Donohue Company holds the broadcast rights to the national celebration (Ep #0126).
- The country is co-hosting the **2026 FIFA World Cup** (June 11 – July 19). Atlanta hosts eight matches, including a semifinal on Wednesday, July 15 (Ep #0133). BSI runs security for the Atlanta matches.
- Midterm elections are on **Tuesday, November 3, 2026**. Every House seat, including Jasmine Olson's, is on the ballot.
- The 2028 presidential race has quietly begun. Georgia Attorney General Arianna Cummings is one of the most talked-about possible candidates.

Washington (all fictional)

Office	Holder	Born / Age	Notes
President	Richard Aldridge	Mar 18, 1958 / 67	Former governor of Ohio. Inaugurated Jan 20, 2025. Courts Donohue money and fears Donohue cameras
Vice President	Karen Molina	Sep 2, 1969 / 56	Former U.S. senator from Arizona. Already the front-runner for 2028, and watching Arianna closely
U.S. Representative, Georgia	Jasmine Olson	Mar 23, 1970 / 55	In office since 1997. Senior member of the House Energy and Commerce Committee, which oversees the media industry her family dominates. Critics never stop pointing that out

The American Economy

- The stock market is near all-time highs, carried by media, AI, and entertainment. The Donohue Company alone is about one-sixth of the S&P 500's value.
- The real-world tech giants exist, but none is worth even half of The Donohue Company.
- The most valuable companies in this story:** The Donohue Company (\$10.0 trillion, public), Smiley Corporation (\$1.6 trillion, public), and Blackwater Security International (\$1.3 trillion, private).

The Crown Rich List, January 2026

Published every January by Crown magazine, which the Donohues own. Rivals call it “the family newsletter.”

Rank	Name	Net worth	Source
1	Marc-Anthony Bullock	\$994B+	BSI, The Donohue Company, investments
2	Victor Donohue	~\$680B	The Donohue Company

Rank	Name	Net worth	Source
3	Joan Donohue	~\$415B	The Donohue Company, royalties
4	Natasha Bullock	~\$330B	The Donohue Company
5	Jasmine & Peter Olson	~\$345B combined	The Donohue Company, Olson Institute
6	Alvin Donohue	~\$200B	The Donohue Company
7	Theodore Donohue family	~\$200B	The Donohue Company
8	Augustus “Gus” Smilley	~\$152B	Smilley Corporation
9	Leonard Smilley	~\$112B	Smilley Corporation
10	Martin Olson	~\$104B	The Donohue Company

Every name in the top ten is a Donohue or a Smilley. Gus Smilley has a framed copy of every list since 1996, each with the Donohue names blacked out.

4. Georgia

Office	Holder	Notes
Governor	William Hartley (b. Jun 6, 1962; 63)	Serving his second and final term, so 2026 is an open-seat governor's race. Appointed Arianna Cummings Attorney General
Attorney General	Arianna Cummings (b. Oct 25, 1992; 33)	Appointed Mon, Mar 17, 2025, after Attorney General Bradley Keane resigned in a bribery scandal. Faces her first statewide election in November 2026
Fulton County District Attorney	Colette Barnes (b. Apr 30, 1979; 46)	Arianna's former chief deputy, appointed interim DA in 2025. Loyal to Arianna, for now

Georgia in 2026

- **Election calendar:** primary Tuesday, May 19 (Ep #0094); runoff Tuesday, June 16 (Ep #0113); general election Tuesday, November 3.
- **The open governor's race** is the biggest prize in the South, and every candidate wants a Donohue endorsement. Season 2 storyline.
- **The film industry:** Georgia's production boom began in the 1950s, when Donohue Pictures built its first soundstages. Today “the Peach State” is the world's busiest filming location.
- **Lake Lanier**, an hour north of Atlanta, is where the rich go for summer and for secrets. It's the setting of the 2011 night that started it all, and of the Season 1 finale.

5. Atlanta, “The Media Capital of the World”

Metro population about 6.4 million. In this world Atlanta is where the world's stories get made. Tourists take the Donohue Studios tour the way they visit the Hollywood sign in ours.

City Office	Holder	Notes
Mayor	Denise Whitlock (b. Dec 15, 1972; 53)	Second term. A Belmont Crest outsider who resents the ridge and needs its money
Chief of Police, APD	Elxa Jackson (b. Aug 29, 1990; 35)	Sworn in Tue, Sep 2, 2025. The youngest chief in the city's history
Former Chief	Walter Jackson (b. Jan 18, 1956; 69)	Chief 2011–2019

Map of the Story

Place	Where	Why it matters
Belmont Crest	1958 Belmont Crest Pkwy NW (30327)	Home of the Donohues. See Document 04
Tuxedo Park	Buckhead, across the ridge	Home of the Smilleys
Donohue Tower	1939 Peachtree St NE, Midtown	108 stories, the tallest building in the South

Place	Where	Why it matters
Smilley Plaza	3400 Peachtree Rd NE, Buckhead	Built in 1996 so Gus could see Donohue Tower from his desk
BSI Tower	2011 Northside Pkwy NW	Blackwater's legitimate face
Atlanta Metropolitan Medical Center	Midtown	Peter's hospital. Victor's surgery (Ep #0102)
Westbrook Academy	Buckhead	School of Emma, Victoria, Lyric, and Trey
APD Headquarters	Downtown	Elxa's office and Jeremy's squad room
Fulton County Courthouse	Downtown	The Whitaker trial
The Beacon Museum	190 Auburn Ave NE, Sweet Auburn	Alexander's original 1939 press room
<i>The Peach Ledger</i>	Auburn Avenue	Journee's newsroom, two blocks from the Beacon Museum
The Chancellor Club	Midtown	Martin's private club, where he makes his offers
SOVEREIGN	Buckhead Village	Alvin's nightclub, opened May 2026
The Well	Westside	Deuce Whitaker's nightclub and Blackwater's Atlanta base
Lucky Seven Karaoke	Buford Highway	Vincent Morrow's back-room office
Paces Ferry Road bridge	Chattahoochee River	Where T-Bone Gaines died
The downtown stadium	Downtown	World Cup semifinal (Ep #0133)

6. The Media Universe

Every headline, broadcast, and post in the show comes from these outlets and platforms. Knowing who owns what tells you who's lying.

Owned by The Donohue Company

Outlet	What it is
<i>The Atlanta Beacon</i>	The family's original 1939 paper; now the South's newspaper of record
BNN (Beacon News Network)	24-hour global news channel
DBC	National broadcast network. Home of <i>Hollywood Heat</i> , hosted by Brielle Knox
The Crown Network	Cable entertainment channel
WDON-TV	Atlanta's No. 1 local station
<i>Crown</i> magazine	Black lifestyle and society bible since 1947; publishes the Crown Rich List
Donohue+	Streaming service, 1.3 billion subscribers

Independent and Rival Outlets

Outlet	What it is
<i>The Peach Ledger</i>	Scrappy independent investigative outlet. Journee Holloway's home. No Donohue money, on principle
<i>The Tea Kettle ATL</i>	Anonymous gossip blog with the biggest audience in Atlanta. Secretly written by Harmony Divine
<i>Marquee</i>	The entertainment industry's trade paper, based in Los Angeles: casting, box office, deals
<i>The Capitol Wire</i>	Washington politics outlet; covers Jasmine and the 2028 field
<i>Wall & Broad</i>	Financial daily; covers the Crown License war
Channel 7 Atlanta	The only local TV news outlet not owned by Donohue

Social Platforms

Platform	What it is	Who uses it
Chirp	Short text posts and trending hashtags	Everyone. Breaking news breaks here first
Glimpse	Photos and 24-hour stories	Grace, Sienna, Coco, the twins
Loop	Short vertical video	The kids; Marc's unhinged comedy clips
Pulse	Live streaming	Galas, verdicts, and anything that might go wrong

The Donohue Company owns 30% of Loop. Smiley owns none of them, and pays all of them.

7. The Underworld and the Law

- **The Blackwater Syndicate** controls 43 countries and every major U.S. city (Document 05). To the street it's "the people from the river." To APD it's "the ghost network." To the FBI it's "Organization X."
- **The Morrow Organization** is Vincent Morrow's Irish-American mob. It was pushed off Atlanta's ports in 2017 and has been starving for a way back ever since.
- **Independent crews** pay Blackwater's "tax" or leave town. Violence in Atlanta's hardest neighborhoods has fallen by half since the 2013 Peace of Peachtree, and nobody in City Hall can explain why.
- **The law:** APD under Chief Elxa Jackson; the Fulton County DA's office under interim DA Colette Barnes; the FBI Atlanta field office under Special Agent in Charge Nadia Brooks; and the Georgia Attorney General, Arianna Cummings, who knows more than any of them.

8. Culture and Society

- **Black Atlanta's social calendar** runs through Belmont Crest: the Country Club's New Year's brunch, the Valentine's Ball, the Juneteenth Jubilee, Fourth of July fireworks, and the Crest Cotillion.
- **Joan vs. Celeste.** The Donohue Foundation Gala and the Smilley Family Foundation Ball fall on the same night every year, and Atlanta society picks a side.
- **HBCUs** are richer than ever: Donohue Hall at Spelman, the Alexander Donohue School of Journalism at Morehouse, and anonymous "Envelope" scholarships that nobody can trace.
- **Pop culture** belongs to Donohue: the *Crown Universe* superhero films, *Kingdom of Kora* games, Donohue Records' chart-toppers, and Donohue Worlds theme parks on four continents.
- **Belmont Crest vs. Tuxedo Park** is Atlanta's favorite rivalry. The kids call it "the Ridge versus the Park."
- **The Envelope.** Every Friday, envelopes of cash appear in Atlanta's neighborhoods. Grandmothers light candles for whoever sends them.

9. Timeline: The Country and the Crest, 1916–2026

Year	Event
1916	Alexander Donohue born on Auburn Avenue (Fri, Mar 3).
1920	Simone Batiste born in New Orleans (Sun, Sep 12).
1939	<i>The Atlanta Beacon</i> publishes its first edition (Mon, Apr 3). The Donohue Company is born.
1941–1945	America goes to war. The Beacon's war correspondents make it the most trusted Black paper in the South.
1947	<i>Crown</i> magazine launches.
1951	WDON-AM puts Black voices on Atlanta radio.
1953	Donohue Pictures founded; Georgia's first soundstages built.
1954	<i>Brown v. Board of Education</i> .
1958	Belmont Crest founded (Sat, May 17). Otis Smilley fired from the Beacon.
1961	Belmont Crest Country Club and Donohue Records open.
1960s	The civil rights movement. The Beacon covers it from inside; Alexander quietly pays for bail and bus fare. The FBI opens a file on him (1963).
1962	Simone's vote keeps the Smilleys out of Belmont Crest.
1964	The Civil Rights Act becomes law.
1966	Gus Smilley proposes to Joan Mercer in New York.
1969	Victor marries Joan (Sat, Jun 14).
1973	Atlanta elects its first Black mayor. The Beacon's front page sells out three printings.
1974	Smilley Corporation founded in Harlem (Mon, Sep 9).
1976	Victor named CEO over Theodore (Mon, Jan 5).
1978	The Donohue Company lists on the NYSE (Mon, Oct 16).
1987	Donohue swallows Paragon Pictures. Hollywood starts moving to Atlanta.
1990	The first Crown License binds Smilley to Donohue.
1996	Atlanta hosts the Summer Olympics, broadcast worldwide on DBC. The Smilleys move to Atlanta. Gus writes the Allegiance Clause.
2001	BNN launches.
2006	Alexander dies (Mon, Jan 9). Victor becomes Chairman and Natasha becomes CEO.
2008	The financial crisis. Donohue buys distressed studios on three continents; Donohue Tower opens in Midtown.
2010	The Blackwater Syndicate founded in secret (Sat, Sep 18).
2011	BSI founded (Mon, Oct 3). The Lake Lanier Labor Day party (Sat, Sep 3).

Year	Event
2012	Lyric Baker born (Apr 20). Emma and Victoria Smilley born (May 10).
2013	The Peace of Peachtree.
2014	Simone Donohue dies at 94 (Sat, Nov 22).
2016	Donohue+ launches worldwide.
2017	Blackwater takes Atlanta's ports from the Morrow Organization. RootsKit launches.
2019	The Donohue Company passes \$1 trillion.
2020	The pandemic. Donohue+ passes 500 million subscribers.
2021	Juneteenth becomes a federal holiday. Julian Cummings's hit-and-run (Sat, Oct 16). Marc gets custody of Lyric (Fri, Feb 12).
2023	Donohue passes \$5 trillion. Marc wins his Oscar.
2024	Richard Aldridge elected President. Elxa marries Jeremy (Sat, Jun 15).
2025	Aldridge inaugurated (Jan 20). Arianna appointed AG (Mar 17). Elxa sworn in as Chief (Sep 2). Donohue closes the year at \$10 trillion (Dec 31).
2026	Mon, Jan 5: Marc-Anthony's 34th birthday. The Succession Covenant. A body in the river. Series premiere.

10. The World's 2026 Calendar

Date	Event	Episode
Monday, January 5, 2026	Series premiere; Marc-Anthony's 34th birthday	#0001
Monday, January 19, 2026	Martin Luther King Jr. Day	#0011
Sunday, February 8, 2026	The Super Bowl	#0026 (morning after)
Saturday, February 14, 2026	Belmont Crest Valentine's Ball	#0031
Sunday, March 15, 2026	The Academy Awards	#0051
Sunday, April 5, 2026	Easter	#0063
Sunday, May 10, 2026	Mother's Day; the twins turn 14	#0088
Tuesday, May 19, 2026	Georgia primary	#0094
Saturday, May 30, 2026	Victor's 80th birthday gala	#0101
Sunday, June 7, 2026	The Tony Awards	#0107
Thursday, June 11, 2026	FIFA World Cup begins	#0111
Tuesday, June 16, 2026	Georgia primary runoff	#0113
Friday, June 19, 2026	Juneteenth Jubilee; Harmony's 34th	#0116
Sunday, June 21, 2026	Father's Day	#0117

Date	Event	Episode
Saturday, July 4, 2026	America's 250th birthday	#0126
Wednesday, July 15, 2026	World Cup semifinal in Atlanta	#0133
Friday, July 24, 2026	The Club votes on the Smilleys	#0140
Thursday, August 6, 2026	First day of 9th grade at Westbrook	#0149
Monday, August 31, 2026	The Crown License deadline, 11:59 PM	#0166
Friday, September 4, 2026	Labor Day weekend on Lake Lanier; Season 1 finale	#0170
Tuesday, November 3, 2026	Midterm elections	Season 2

11. What the World Is Reading: Monday, January 5, 2026, 7:00 AM

The morning of the premiere, before the body surfaces and before the gala.

Outlet	Headline
<i>The Atlanta Beacon</i>	HAPPY 34TH, MARC-ANTHONY: GOLDEN BOY'S BIRTHDAY GALA TONIGHT AT SUMMIT HOUSE
<i>Wall & Broad</i>	DONOHUE ENDS 2025 AT \$10 TRILLION; ANALYSTS WATCH FOR SUCCESSION SIGNAL
<i>Marquee</i>	BULLOCK EYES <i>SWEET CHARIOT</i> REVIVAL: "THE TONY IS THE LAST ONE"
<i>The Capitol Wire</i>	IS GEORGIA'S AG READY FOR 2028? CUMMINGS WON'T SAY NO
<i>The Peach Ledger</i>	SEVEN YEARS OF SILENCE: WHO FUNDS ATLANTA'S "GHOST NETWORK"?
<i>The Tea Kettle ATL</i>	BLIND ITEM: Which billionaire heiress has turned down every party the birthday boy has ever thrown?

Trending on Chirp, 7:00 AM

- **#HBDMarcAnthony** (2.1M posts): "The richest man alive still does his own stunts AND his own grocery shopping. Protect him at all costs."
- **#DonohueTenTrillion** (640K posts)
- **#RidgeVsThePark** (88K posts): "Smilleys not invited to the gala AGAIN. Tuxedo Park in shambles."